

SPONSORED SPECIAL FEATURE

Wine Spectator

THE DUCKHORN COLLECTION

Defining American Fine Wine



Crafting **Timeless Wines** From Iconic Terroirs

Celebrating 50 YEARS Of Napa Valley Heritage

THE DUCKHORN PERSPECTIVE



A family of world-class wineries united by a singular pursuit of excellence



FOR FIFTY YEARS, The Duckhorn Collection has stood at the center of American fine wine—rooted in vineyard integrity, generational stewardship, and the belief that exceptional wines begin with exceptional sites. Ours is a distinctly American story, shaped by landscape, craftsmanship, and a hospitality that is both timeless and modern.

This philosophy comes fully to life in our new Napa Valley home on the Silverado Trail. Here, guests experience our portfolio through thoughtful tastings, seasonal pairings from our world-class culinary team, and an atmosphere defined by warmth, ease, and a remarkable sense of place. It is a setting that reflects the spirit of our founders—welcoming, refined, and deeply connected to the vineyards that shape our wines.

*Crafted by Place.
Defined by Hospitality.*

The wineries featured in the Collection each carry forward our shared vision: winemaking excellence, respect for land, and a deep understanding of how place defines character. Together, they represent Napa warmth and structure, coastal intensity, limestone purity, cool-climate precision, and the breadth of California's most compelling sites.

This feature highlights five of our wineries and the people and philosophies behind the wines—the growers, winemakers, and stewards whose craft and commitment elevate every bottle. Their work reflects what American fine wine can be today—and where we are headed next.



FPO
Signature

Robert Hanson
CEO, The Duckhorn Collection

DUCKHORN VINEYARDS

Five Decades In. Still Defining What's Next.

A House Built on Hospitality

Dan and Margaret Duckhorn believed that great wine should be shared generously—a principle woven into the estate’s tasting culture from the beginning. Their early commitment to Merlot helped define Napa Valley’s reputation, and their philosophy continues to guide the estate: inviting, personal, elevated without excess.



The Importance of Vineyard Quality



Great wine starts in the vineyard. slope and sun exposure, soil composition and even the clones planted shape every decision in the cellar—and define the character in the glass. Guided by Rob Sorensen, The Duckhorn Collection stewards exceptional sites with intention and care.

Read the Full Story Scan to explore how this farmer-first approach drives vineyard quality across the estate.



The Merlot Benchmark

For decades, Duckhorn has stood at the forefront of American Merlot. Nowhere is that legacy more evident than at Three Palms Vineyard, a site of volcanic stones and warm exposures that yields wines of singular depth and longevity. It remains one of Napa’s defining expressions—a testament to belief, perseverance, and site.

Precision with A Human Touch

Duckhorn’s approach emphasizes discipline—night harvesting, small-lot fermentations, and one of Napa’s most meticulous barrel programs. Each lot is handled individually, preserving purity, structure, and the character of diverse estate sites. It is winemaking grounded in restraint and respect, resulting in wines that are both expressive and enduring.



RENÉE ARY | Vice President of Winemaking

DUCKHORN VINEYARDS has shaped Napa Valley’s modern identity for nearly half a century. Its approach unites estate rigor, an unbroken winemaking lineage, and a hospitality culture defined by genuine warmth—shaped early on by Dan and Margaret Duckhorn’s admiration for Bordeaux and their conviction that Merlot could thrive in Napa. From Merlot to Sauvignon Blanc and Cabernet, the wines reflect intention, balance, and a respect for detail that begins in the vineyard and carries through every touchpoint of the guest experience.



				
Three Palms Merlot Layered and powerful, revealing Bing cherry, cocoa, slate, dusty tannins, and an earthy, mineral-driven finish.	Merlot Velvety and expressive, with plum, black cherry, baking spice, lively acidity, and a polished, lingering finish.	Cabernet Sauvignon Elegant yet structured, offering dark red berries, fig, boysenberry, firm tannins, and a long,	Chardonnay Rich yet balanced, showcasing pear, citrus, crème brûlée, subtle salinity, and a long, juicy finish.	Sauvignon Blanc Crisp and vibrant, with pineapple, guava, melon, lively acidity, silky texture, and a refined mineral finish.

“Duckhorn’s commitment to detail and hospitality is unmistakable. Every wine, every visit, reflects a deep respect for place—and a belief that great wines create meaningful moments.”

—RENÉE ARY



JULIEN HOWSEPIAN | Winemaker

BURGUNDIAN OBSESSION, CALIFORNIA SOUL

“Great Pinot Noir doesn’t shout—it reveals. Its beauty lies in precision, in purity, and in the way it captures landscape with effortless clarity. Few varietals connect place and emotion so completely.”

—JULIEN HOWSEPIAN

PINOT NOIR transforms landscape into emotion—demanding in the vineyard, delicate in the cellar, and transcendent in the glass. Across The Duckhorn Collection, it finds three distinct voices that together define America’s Burgundian lineage: *Kosta Browne*, *Goldeneye*, and *Calera*.

Each estate captures a different facet of Pinot’s expressive range. Across the Sonoma Coast’s fog-defined ridges and coastal expressions, Kosta Browne stands at the pinnacle—translating site diversity into Pinot Noir of exceptional precision and depth. In Anderson Valley, Goldeneye crafts wines of poise and purity, where redwoods and ocean air shape an unmistakable cool-climate elegance. High atop the limestone slopes of Mt. Harlan, Calera channels a Burgundian ideal of minerality and restraint, producing wines of tension, longevity, and grace.

Together, these three estates form a singular vision of Pinot authority—diverse in geography, unified in purpose. Each speaks fluently of its place yet shares the same devotion to detail that defines The Duckhorn Collection. From coastal Pacific vineyards to mountain interiors, they embody finesse over force, clarity over excess, and craftsmanship over convention.

THE ART OF SITE

KOSTA BROWNE

Kosta Browne approaches Pinot Noir as a mosaic of singular sites—each block, clone, and exposure vinified independently to preserve nuance. Native ferments and temperature-disciplined cellar work reveal the subtleties of soil, fog patterns, and coastal influence. The result is a portfolio defined by precision and depth: powerful yet balanced Pinots with luminous fruit, fine structure, and unmistakable site signatures. Many of these small-lot wines are made in highly limited quantities and largely allocated to mailing-list members and winery visitors. It is terroir translated through intent—a philosophy of listening closely and intervening sparingly to allow every vineyard to speak with clarity.



Craft Without Compromise

Every detail in Kosta Browne’s cellar is built around honoring delicacy. Micro-fermentations, careful extraction, and thoughtful élevage preserve the grape’s natural energy while refining texture and depth. The team balances intuition with technical rigor, shaping wines that are expressive without heaviness and structured without austerity. It is a modern, disciplined approach supporting a portfolio of roughly a dozen rare, site-specific Pinot Noir and Chardonnay expressions, widely renowned and sought after by collectors and wine lovers.



4-Barrel California Pinot Noir
Created as a thank you to our earliest collectors, produced from just four barrels each vintage.

Gap's Crown Vineyard Sonoma Coast Pinot Noir
Reflective of an extraordinary 20-year partnership that began shortly after the vineyard was planted, and a cherished favorite.

Beaune Premier Cru Burgundy Pinot Noir
An elegant and exceptional expression of the Cote d'Or region and its revered hillsides.



CALERA

Calera remains one of California’s most distinctive expressions of Pinot Noir. Perched high on Mt. Harlan, the vineyards rise from rare limestone soils, fierce diurnal shifts, and conditions that challenge the vines at every turn. The wines are shaped by altitude and austerity—native fermentations, whole-cluster structure, gravity-fed handling, and long, patient aging that preserves purity and lift.

Calera Jensen Vineyard Pinot Noir
Vibrant and expressive, with red cherry, plum, spice, supple tannins, energetic acidity, and a beautifully balanced finish.



Mt. Harlan: A Singular American AVA

Calera’s philosophy has remained unchanged since its founding: honor the vineyard, respect the mountain, and let the site speak with clarity. The result is Pinot Noir that feels sculpted more by geology than technique—precise, mineral, and unmistakably Calera.

“Calera Pinot Noir reflects a landscape as much as a grape. Limestone, altitude, and discipline converge to create wines of rare clarity and soul.” —MIKE WALLER, WINEMAKER

GOLDENEYE

Goldeneye channels the coastal intensity of Anderson Valley into Pinot Noirs defined by depth, tone, and a vivid sense of place. Its estate vineyards, ranging from warm mid-valley slopes to wind-swept deep-end ridges, offer a dramatic palette of textures. Sustainable farming, measured extraction, and a modernized oak program allow the valley’s natural signatures, redwoods, ocean breezes, Pennyroyal herbs, to find clear expression in the wines.

Goldeneye Anderson Valley Pinot Noir
Elegant and nuanced, offering cherry, herbal lift, subtle earth, silky tannins, fresh acidity, and a long finish.



“Goldeneye Pinot Noir carries the imprint of Anderson Valley—wild, aromatic, and resonant. It’s a region defined by patience, precision, and coastal character.”
—KRISTEN MCMAHAN, WINEMAKER

Pinot Noir with Coastal Intensity

Confluence brings generosity and mid-palate weight; Gowan Creek contributes structure, richness, and natural acidity; The Narrows adds spice, tension, and cool-climate definition. Together, they form a uniquely expressive portfolio. At the pinnacle is 10 Degrees, crafted from the vintage’s most compelling barrels—an elevated snapshot of the valley’s contrasts in one composition.



Meet The Makers

A conversation with the winemakers who shape the wines



FROM LEFT TO RIGHT | Mike Waller, Renée Ary, Kristen McMahan, Cara Morrison, Julien Howsepian

RENÉE ARY | Duckhorn Vineyards
Q: Duckhorn helped define American Merlot. What is the north star of Duckhorn Merlot today?
A: Merlot is where Duckhorn started—supple, friendly texture, but built at a luxury level. The goal is a serious wine that is also immediately appealing: silky, layered, with bright acidity, and a perception of sweetness that comes only from fruit.

JULIEN HOWSEPIAN | Kosta Browne
Q: You’ve described your approach to Pinot Noir as “controlled freedom.” What does that mean in practice?
A: “Great Pinot is at its best when you resist the urge to over correct, allowing the wine to become what it wants to be. Consistency isn’t sameness, it’s signature. Our job is to guide, not dominate.”

KRISTEN MCMAHAN | Goldeneye
Q: What should your Pinot Noir communicate about Anderson Valley the moment it hits the glass?
A: “Sense of place. If you’ve been here, I want the wine to take you back – towering redwoods, shifting coastal air, pennyroyal on the breeze, that golden light in late afternoon. If you haven’t been here, I want our wines to encourage you to visit and explore.”

MIKE WALLER | Calera
Q: Calera is one of California’s original Pinot Noir pioneers. What is the philosophy that still guides every vintage?
A: The through-line is simple: change nothing in the cellar so the vineyards can speak. Native fermentation, whole cluster, gravity-fed, 18 months in barrel, then bottled unfiltered—the point is restraint, so Mt. Harlan shows itself clearly.

CARA MORRISON | Sonoma-Cutrer
Q: Sonoma-Cutrer is synonymous with Chardonnay. What defines the house style, year after year?
A: Consistent, crisp, and balanced. The wines are fruit-forward and refreshing, with real acidity, but never over-oaked or heavily buttery. Evolution happens quietly, through refinement, not reinvention.

Read the complete interviews.



SONOMA-CUTRER

Sonoma-Cutrer was founded on one idea: perfecting Chardonnay. Four decades later, the winery remains synonymous with crisp, balanced, terroir-driven Chardonnay shaped by the Russian River Valley’s cool climate. Vineyard-specific harvesting, barrel fermentation, selected French oak, and modest malolactic preserve brightness and precision. Les Pierres’ river-rock soils add minerality, while The Cutrer vineyard brings richness and breadth. The style is refined, consistent, and deeply satisfying.

Sonoma-Cutrer Les Pierres
Crisp and fruit-forward, with citrus, green apple, mineral notes, bright acidity, and a smooth, lingering texture.



A Chardonnay for the Table

While many wineries chase range, Sonoma-Cutrer has spent decades refining a single expression: Chardonnay defined by balance and flavor—bright, crisp, composed, and inherently food-friendly.

“Sonoma-Cutrer has spent forty years refining one philosophy—Chardonnay shaped by balance, place, and precision. The result is elegance in every glass.”

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THE MILESTONES THAT BUILT A COLLECTION

And Helped Define American Fine Wine

DAN AND MARGARET DUCKHORN set out to make wines of lasting distinction in Napa Valley. Inspired by the great wines of Bordeaux—and guided by a belief in restraint, balance, and long-term thinking—they committed themselves to vineyards and to letting place lead. Over time, Duckhorn became a benchmark, and the Collection it inspired reflects a shared pursuit of excellence across California’s great winegrowing regions.

A Vineyard-First Vision Takes Root

1976 | Duckhorn Vineyards is established in Napa Valley with an early, defining commitment to Merlot—setting a house style centered on balance and elegance at a time when Cabernet Sauvignon dominated much of the valley.



Mid-1980s–Today | THREE PALMS VINEYARD reveals itself early as a singular Merlot site—delivering grapes with exceptional structure and depth. Decades of dedication culminate in Duckhorn’s acquisition of the vineyard in 2015, securing long-term stewardship of America’s most important Merlot site.



Goldeneye Founded in Anderson Valley

1996 | Duckhorn expands beyond Napa, establishing Goldeneye and signaling an early, deliberate commitment to cool-climate Pinot Noir.

Defining Cool-Climate California Chardonnay

Early 1980s | Sonoma-Cutrer emerges as an early leader in Russian River Valley Chardonnay, establishing a Burgundian-influenced model built on site specificity, crisp acidity and balance—helping shape America’s modern Love affair with fine Chardonnay.



THE 2009 KOSTA BROWNE Sonoma Coast Pinot Noir is named *Wine Spectator* Wine of the Year, recognizing Pinot Noir of rare precision and cementing Kosta Browne’s place among America’s most influential fine-wine estates.



Josh Jensen Pinot Pioneer

2013 | Calera founder Josh Jensen is recognized as a defining voice in American Pinot Noir, reinforcing the Collection’s role in shaping Pinot’s evolution.



THE 2014 THREE PALMS VINEYARD earns *Wine Spectator* Wine of the Year, marking Renée Ary’s first vintage and affirming the wine’s enduring excellence and the lasting distinction of its vineyard.

A Portrait of Place

California’s great wine regions form the foundation of the Collection. From the valley floor to coastal ridgelines and mountain slopes, each estate reflects a different facet of California terroir, and connected through a shared standard of excellence.



The Duckhorn Collection Opens

2025 | A new Napa Valley destination opens on Silverado Trail, where expanded tastings and culinary experiences allow guests to experience the full Duckhorn Collection within a beautiful vineyard setting.

WINE SPECTATOR'S RECOMMENDED RELEASES



DUCKHORN VINEYARDS

Merlot Napa Valley Three Palms Vineyard 2022	94
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Merlot Napa Valley Three Palms Vineyard 2021	92
Cabernet Sauvignon Stags Leap District 2021	93
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Merlot Carneros Hyde Vineyard 2019	93
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GOLDENEYE

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KOSTA BROWNE

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CALERA VINEYARDS

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SONOMA-CUTRER

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